



Currency Risk Management: From Theory to Practice

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We recently [highlighted](#) growing interest among financial institutions in a more integrated framework for managing risk, return and liquidity at the total-fund level. The challenge, often described as the total portfolio approach (TPA), is no longer whether TPA makes sense in theory, but how institutions can implement it within their own governance structures, risk systems and organisational set-up.

Holistic currency risk management, a key pillar of this approach, is becoming a more central part of the discussion. We recently published [Dynamic FX Portfolio Hedging: A deep dive and why you should use it](#) and [why and how to use a currency signal](#) on applying this principle to FX risk management. Since the papers were published last month, we have discussed these ideas with more than 35 clients. Here, we summarise the main findings from our TPA study and recent client conversations on implementing TPA in FX:

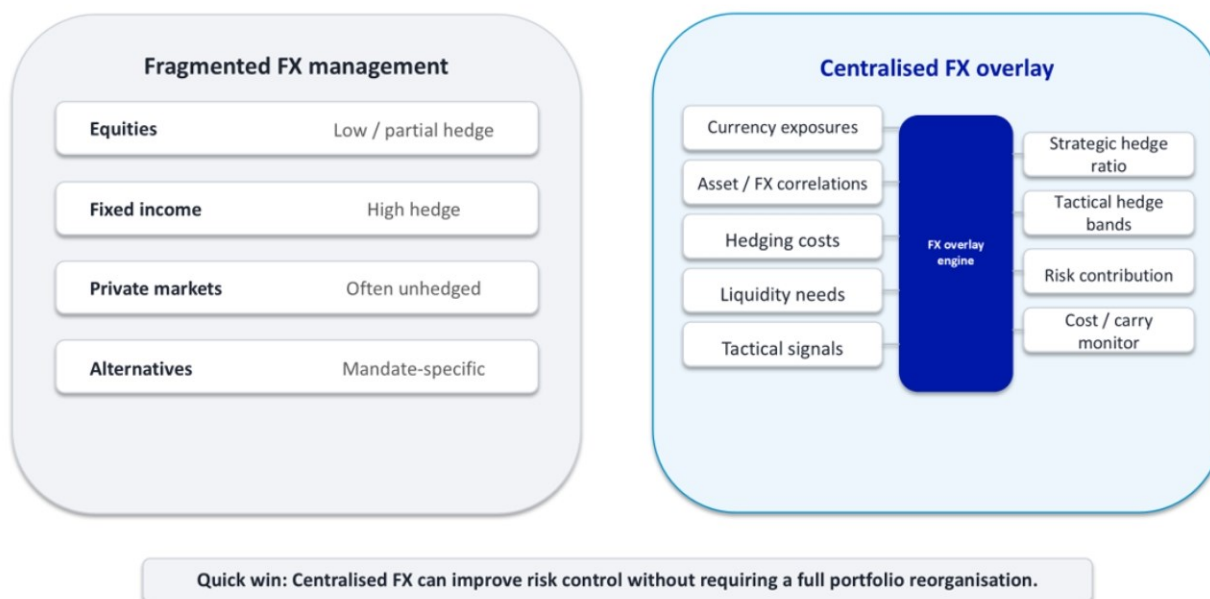
- **Currency risk is often overlooked or managed in silos:** Although this has long been the norm, we are now seeing more interest in managing currency risk more actively. Choosing not to hedge is itself a risk decision and, if made passively, can affect portfolio outcomes. Across asset classes, bond exposures are typically hedged more than equities, but clients responded positively to the idea of managing FX exposures centrally. Regionally, the upcoming Dutch pension reforms are also prompting funds to take a more active approach to FX risk.
- **Defining the key objectives for currency risk management:** While a very fundamental yet debated question was should one manage currency risk to add returns to the fund or assess it from the risk management angle. FX is itself an asset class and can generate returns in certain circumstances. Our approach has been to build currency hedging programmes that aim to manage the stability or risk of the portfolio while trying to preserve the portfolio returns. There was consensus on looking for returns from core assets while looking to FX for operational efficiency.
- **FX risk and benchmark-aware funds:** An important theme in our conversations was how to manage currency risk without straying too far from benchmark performance. Many funds are measured against market indices that are unhedged—for example, equity portfolios often track the MSCI World. Another common reference point is peer performance. These practical constraints can be incorporated into our framework and may still allow for efficiency gains over standard approaches.
- **Hedging instruments such as forwards and options:** While forwards remain the main tool for managing currency risk, options are becoming more widely used. Their embedded cost efficiencies have made them



increasingly attractive as a secondary instrument. Funds that must maintain a fully hedged currency exposure are also using options to introduce more flexibility and improve efficiency.

- **A deep dive into currency exposure beyond direct holdings:** Another important theme was the need for a more holistic view of currency exposure by looking beyond portfolio holdings to underlying economic exposure. For example, if a fund owns a US stock whose business is materially exposed to the Japanese yen, the fund may also have indirect yen exposure. While there is no simple way to measure this, one possible approach discussed was to review company annual and quarterly reports to estimate those exposures.
- **Managing currency risk in private markets:** Currency management is more difficult in private markets because the timing and size of cash flows are uncertain. One emerging approach is to model expected private-asset distributions under different scenarios, using long-term currency volatilities and correlations, and then design hedging strategies that balance risk reduction against the carry cost of forwards and options.
- **Cashflow management:** A key practical issue in hedging is managing margin calls, especially when the hedge moves against you. For example, if a currency you are hedging against starts to strengthen, the hedged position can experience large swings. While our framework helps answer whether and how much to hedge, it also shows that hedging 100% with forwards is often inefficient because FX exposures change over time. Business solutions are available to help clients manage the resulting liquidity needs.

Figure 1: Currency risk – the underrated opportunity under the total portfolio approach



Source: Deutsche Bank Research



Figure 2: Currency risk management – medium to high focus for most clients

	Governance	Reference portfolio/ Risk budget	Macro overlays	Private markets	Liquidity/ Rebalancing	FX management	Portable alpha	Risk systems/ Factor models
North America	High	High	High	High	High	Low	High	High
Asia-Pacific	High	High	Med	Med	Med	High	Med	High
Middle-East	High	Med	Med	High	Med	Med	Med	High
Europe	High	Med	Med	Med	Med	Med	Med	Med

Heatmap summarising the themes that featured most prominently in TPA-related discussions across regions. High / Medium / Low indicates relative emphasis in discussions, not implementation success.

Source: Deutsche Bank Research



Appendix 1

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